

Adaptive Potential of Emotion-focused Coping

Emotion-Focused Coping

Emotion-focused coping is a type of stress management that attempts to reduce negative emotional responses that occur due to exposure to stressors.

Negative emotions such as fear, anxiety, aggression, depression, humiliation are reduced or removed by the individual by various methods of coping. Emotion-focused coping can be positive or negative. Positive examples include talking or writing about their emotions through therapy or journaling, mindful meditation, or distraction with other activities. Negative examples of emotion-focused coping (that typically are not beneficial or helpful in the long term) are suppression of emotions, avoidance, and alcohol or drug use in order to dull or avoid emotions.

7 Emotion-Focused Coping Techniques for Uncertain Times

When a challenge comes up for you, you probably have a handful of go-to strategies to help you deal with it. Even if your approach varies slightly from problem to problem, you probably manage most difficulties in similar ways. You might, for example, be a problem solver. When navigating a challenge or stressful event, you go straight to the source and work at it until you've either fixed what's wrong or brought your stress down to a more manageable level. What if taking immediate action isn't your strong point? Maybe you try to hack your emotions by considering the situation from a different perspective or leaning on loved ones for support.

These two approaches represent two distinct coping strategies:

- **Problem-focused coping** involves handling stress by facing it head-on and taking action to resolve the underlying cause.
- **Emotion-focused coping** involves regulating your feelings and emotional response to the problem instead of addressing the problem.

Both strategies can have benefits, but emotion-focused coping may be particularly useful in certain situations.

Emotion-focused coping skills help you process and work through unwanted or painful emotions and reactions. In other words, this approach helps you manage your emotions rather than outside circumstances.

This approach won't help you solve a problem directly, but it's a great tool to have for dealing with stressful situations you can't change or control.

1. Meditation

Meditation helps you learn to acknowledge and sit with all of your thoughts and experiences, even the difficult ones. The key goal of meditation? **Mindfulness: to recognize thoughts as they come up, accept them, and let them go without stewing over them or judging yourself for having them.** You can practice mindfulness anytime, anywhere, and it won't cost you anything. It may feel a little awkward, even unhelpful, at first, and it can take some time before it feels natural. If you stick with it, you'll generally begin seeing some benefits before long. If you're new to meditation; get started by learning more about [different types](#) or trying [this easy body scan exercise](#).

2. Journaling

Journaling is a great way to sort through and come to terms with challenging emotions. When something goes wrong, you might experience a lot of complicated, conflicting feelings. They might feel jumbled up inside you, making the thought of sorting them out exhausting. Or, maybe you're not even sure how to name what you're feeling with words. Exhaustion and confusion are valid feelings and can be a good starting point for putting pen to paper. Sometimes, [writing down your feelings](#) — no matter how messy or complex they are — is the first step in working through them. You might eventually find that journaling offers a type of emotional catharsis, as you purge them from your mind and into your journal.

To get the most out of journaling, try:

- **writing every day, even if you only have 5 minutes**
- writing whatever comes to mind — don't worry about editing or censoring yourself
- keeping track of any mood or emotional changes you experience and any factors that might be contributing to the pattern, whether that's your exercise routine, certain foods, or particular relationships

3. Positive thinking

Optimism won't solve problems alone, but it can certainly boost your emotional wellness.

It's important to understand that optimistic or positive thinking does not involve ignoring your problems. It's about giving challenges a positive spin and finding pockets of joy to help you get through them.

To add more positive thinking to your life, try:

1. **Building yourself up with positive self-talk instead of talking down to yourself**
2. **Recognizing your successes** instead of focusing on "failures"
3. **Laughing off mistakes**

4. Reminding yourself you can always try again

All these things are easier said than done, but with a bit of practice, they'll start to feel more natural.

4. Forgiveness

It's easy to focus on feelings of injustice or unfairness when someone wrongs you or does something unkind. Most of the time, though, you can't do anything to change the hurt you've sustained. In other words, the damage is done, and there's nothing to do but let go and move forward. Forgiveness can help you let go of hurt and begin healing from it. Of course, forgiveness doesn't always happen easily. It can take some time to come to terms with your pain before you feel able to forgive.

Practicing forgiveness can benefit your emotional wellness in a number of ways. You might notice:

- reduced stress and [anger](#)
- increased [compassion](#)
- greater empathy
- stronger [interpersonal relationships](#)

5. Reframing

When you reframe a situation, you look at it from another perspective. This can help you consider the bigger picture instead of getting stuck on little details, as difficult or unpleasant as those details sometimes are. Say, for example, your relationship has been struggling over the past few months, primarily because you and your partner haven't had much time to do things together or communicate about problems. Suddenly, you lose your job and find that you're now spending plenty of time at home. Not working isn't ideal, of course, but for the moment there's nothing you can do to change that situation. Instead of letting frustration and boredom build up, you can look at the bright side of the situation: You now have plenty of time to reconnect with your partner and strengthen your relationship.

6. Talking it out

Burying or pushing away negative emotions usually doesn't do much to improve them. You might not actively notice these unwanted emotions if you work very hard at keeping them hidden, but they do eventually tend to resurface.

In the meantime, they can trickle out in the form of:

- mood changes
- emotional distress
- physical symptoms like muscle tension or head pain

It's generally a good idea to talk about your feelings to any others involved in the situation.

They may not even realize they had an impact on you unless you tell them. Communicating your difficulties won't always resolve them, but if an approach to resolution does exist, you're more likely to discover it together. Talking about your emotions to a trusted loved one can also help you feel better, especially when there's no good solution to your problem.

Friends and family can provide social and emotional support by listening with empathy and validating your feelings.

7. Working with a therapist

Some serious concerns can cause a lot of distress, especially when you can't do anything to improve your situation. Maybe you're going through a [breakup](#), facing a life-threatening health concern, or dealing with grief. There's not much you can do to change these circumstances and dealing with the painful emotions that come up on your own can be hard. But there's no need to go it alone.

A trusted mental health professional can help you manage emotional distress by offering guidance on any of the emotion-focused coping strategies above. They can also provide support that's more specifically tailored to your situation.

The bottom line

In an ideal world, you'd be able to face all your problems head-on and solve them right away. In reality, though, many challenges are beyond our control. Emotion-focused coping can help you weather these challenges and build resilience.

Adaptive Coping

Adaptive coping includes cognitive and behavioural efforts to manage stressful conditions or associated [emotional distress](#). Like social resources, adaptive coping operates as a protective factor that decreases the adverse effects of life stressors when they occur and that can also reduce the likelihood of stressor occurrence. People who rely more on active [coping strategies](#), such as problem solving and information seeking, tend to adapt better to life stressors. Although the stress resistance model emphasizes resilience, coping styles may also involve vulnerabilities. For example, avoidance coping strategies, such as denial and wishful thinking, are generally associated with increased [psychological distress](#). In addition, coping styles can affect physical health indirectly through these psychological reactions. Moreover, coping styles are linked to physical health indirectly through health risk behaviours such as cigarette smoking, alcohol use, and lack of adherence to medical regimens.

Processing and Expressing Emotion

We advocate two points of departure from the traditional emotion- and problem-focused conceptualization of coping. First, we recommend distinguishing, both conceptually and empirically, among emotion-focused strategies that involve active movement toward (e.g., active acceptance, emotional expression, positive reappraisal) versus away from (e.g., mental disengagement) a stressful encounter. This distinction is supported by hierarchical

factor analyses revealing that the problem- and emotion-focused coping dimensions are subsumed by a more fundamental distinction between approach-oriented and avoidance-oriented processes (Tobin, Holroyd, Reynolds, & Wigal, 1989). Moreover, we advocate attention to distinct strategies within the realms of approach and avoidance. This suggestion counters the common practice of combining diverse coping strategies under the umbrella of emotion-focused coping. For example, **expressing one's emotions surrounding a stressor and coming to reappraise it positively** both may involve **approaching the problem**, but they may have distinct precursors and adaptive consequences. Here **we focus on the approach-oriented coping strategies** of **processing and expressing emotion**.

The second recommended point of departure from the extant coping literature concerns the operationalization of emotional approach coping and our focus on its adaptive potential. Stanton et al. (1994) demonstrated that many published emotion-focused coping items are contaminated by psychological distress or self-deprecation, suggesting that at least part of the frequently cited association between emotion-focused coping and maladjustment results from overlap between putative coping items and items measuring distress. To measure coping through actively processing and expressing emotions, Stanton and colleagues (1994, 2000b) developed items that are unconfounded by distress, and it is these items or other unconfounded measures that we recommend for use in future research on coping through emotional approach. In the remainder of this chapter, we focus on the operationalization and potentially adaptive function of coping through emotional processing and expression. This focus necessarily causes us to neglect a substantial literature related to other potentially adaptive approach-oriented coping mechanisms. For example, **coping through active acceptance** and use of humor were associated with lower distress in women with breast cancer (Carver et al., 1993). The interested reader can refer to other chapters in this volume for discussions of additional potentially positive coping strategies, such as benefit finding and reminding, humor, and spirituality.

Assessment and Current Research

Several **self-report measures** are **available of dispositional constructs relevant to emotion that possess** sound evidence of reliability and validity. These include, among others, the **Berkeley Expressivity Questionnaire** (Gross & John, 1995, 1997); the Affect Intensity Measure (Larsen, Diener, & Emmons, 1986); the **Emotional Expressiveness Questionnaire** (King & Emmons, 1990); the Ambivalence Over Emotional Expressiveness Questionnaire (King & Emmons, 1990); and the **Family Expressiveness Questionnaire** (Halberstadt, 1986). However, we were unable to locate measures of coping through emotional processing and expression that were directed specifically toward assessing emotion-oriented responses in stressful encounters and that did not contain distress-contaminated items. Hence, we sought to develop scales to assess these constructs (Stanton, Kirk, Cameron, & Danoff-Burg, 2000b).

Clinical Interventions

It is clear from the foregoing that the experience and expression of emotion may be adaptive or maladaptive. In fact, most clients presenting for psychotherapy share the characteristic of some dysfunctional emotional patterns (Mahoney, 1991). Although some clinical approaches historically have touted pure expression as therapeutic, theorists now suggest that a central goal of psychotherapy and of successful human development is balanced emotional expression in which emotions are recognized, understood, and communicated appropriately in a way that eventually prompts a reduction in distress (Kennedy-Moore & Watson, 1999). Such therapies focus not just on unbridled expression of emotion but rather on emotional processing and expression that serve functions such as regulating arousal, fostering self-understanding, enhancing problem-solving, and improving interpersonal relationships.

Directions for Research

Our investigation of coping through emotional approach has begun with self-report items that are brief and general in nature. Findings of initial studies have generated numerous, specific questions for research. Further specification of the functional and dysfunctional aspects of coping through emotional approach is of central importance. One important element of the emotional approach coping construct requiring closer scrutiny is the role of intentionality (Compas, Connor, Osowiecki, & Welch, 1997), that is, the conscious and purposive use of emotional processing and expression. This intentionality is embedded in the emotional approach items we have evaluated (e.g., “I take time to express my emotions”) and may be intrinsic to the adaptiveness of emotional approach. When non volitional, emotional processing may become maladaptive rumination, and emotional expression may produce destructive outbursts. Continued examination of: (a) individual difference characteristics of the copers, such as hope, developmental attributes, and gender; (b) the nature of the stressor, such as its controllability, severity, and timing of emotional approach coping relative to stressor onset; (c) the specific emotions processed and expressed; and (d)s aspects of the environmental context, including proximal social support and more distal cultural receptivity to emotional approach, also will facilitate the identification of for whom and under what conditions coping through emotional approach is effective. Further, developmental antecedents of emotional approach coping and mechanisms through which it produces effects warrant exploration. In addressing these research questions, the broader literatures on emotion regulation, developmental psychology, biological psychology, evolutionary psychology, and others will be useful in generating hypotheses and constructing methodologies.